

11 Ways to Be Generous on a Budget

Love to be generous with your friends and family? Tired of having the gift-giving and "chipping in" budget be out of control when you are scrimping and saving in every other area? Following are some ideas to continue the tradition of generosity that don't necessarily involve cash or driving your budget into the ditch.

1. Reach out and touch someone



Find a great unlimited calling plan and a super communications package. There are plenty of landline calling plans out there that offer unlimited North American calling. Some even include a few European countries for a nominal fee. Pair that with a slamming cell phone plan and great Internet options. There are plenty of ways to offer support that don't involve writing a check. E-cards, calling to brainstorm ideas or offer condolences, or just touching base with your friends and family on a regular basis to share the love are all more than worthy.

2. DIY gifts

Dry mixes in a jar, building a picnic table, planting a flower garden, a car tune-up, mending, making someone's favorite dinner, dropping off a casserole during a sickness or family crisis . . . it's not all homemade place-mats in this category.

3. Bartering

This may seem like an odd item to include in a list of generosity ideas, but bear with me. What if you have a friend or colleague whom you respect who is trying to get their business off its feet? Rather than charging them, or giving something valuable from your service list away that will leave you feeling out of balance, consider letting them swap services. A custom paint job on their storefront sign for a full-body hot stone massage for example. Then you also get to be one of the people that can give a testimonial on their brochure, and they get to feel professional rather than like a charity case.

4. The gift of time

This relates a bit to the first one, but could also involve stopping by to hold someone's hand during a chemo